

What Counts as Evidence? Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Cross-AOK • 35-45 min

Category	Cross-AOK	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	what-counts-as-evidence

Big idea: AOKs use different standards of evidence.

Overview

Students compare standards of evidence across AOKs.

Student Prompt

Inspect What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Claims from mathematics, art, history, science, and ethics sorted by evidence type. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A card set with proof, testimony, data, interpretation, and expert judgement. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
What Counts as Evidence? Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A comparison of what each AOK accepts and rejects as evidence. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — AOKs use different standards of evidence.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Does evidence mean the same thing in every AOK?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how aoks use different standards of evidence.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Claims from mathematics, art, history, science, and ethics sorted by evidence type.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Claims from mathematics, art, history, science, and ethics sorted by evidence type.
- A card set with proof, testimony, data, interpretation, and expert judgement.
- A comparison of what each AOK accepts and rejects as evidence.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Assign each group an AOK: mathematics, natural sciences, human sciences, history or arts.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Each group decides what evidence would support the claim in that AOK.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Groups present their evidence standard.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	The class discusses whether the same claim means the same thing in every AOK.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may apply one AOK's standard of evidence to all knowledge claims.
- Students may equate certainty with value or usefulness.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Compares standards of evidence across at least two AOKs.
- Explains how a claim changes when method, context, or audience changes.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Same Object, Different AOK
- Reliability Ranking
- Music and Emotion Experiment